set beyond the metros—Chanderi for *Stree*, Arunachal Pradesh for *Bhediya* (2022) and the Konkan region for *Munjya* (2024). Vijan hadn't conceived the universe when *Stree* (2018) was being developed. But advice from Hollywood producer Charles 'Chuck' Roven in 2012-13 over dinner in Los Angeles had stayed: "Build your own box, build your characters." After *Stree* became a surprise superhit, Vijan did just that. By interspersing characters from the films (*Stree*, *Bhediya* and *Munjya*), Vijan has built himself an IP (intellectual property) that's reaping dividends at the box office. Maddock has announced eight more titles in the universe, with films flowing until 2028. This year's addition will be *Thama*, featuring Ayushmann Khurrana and Rashmika Mandanna and set in the South.

WITHOUT SUPERSTARS

Horror comedies are only part of Maddock's bouquet. There are family comedies and romances like *Hindi Medium* (2017), *Bala* (2019) and *Luka Chuppi* (2019), historic/mythology which started with *Chhaava* and armed forces dramas (*Skyforce* and the upcoming *Ikkis*). "We like making artistic films that resonate with a new, emerging India," says Vijan. "Ours is a content-first approach. Anyone who has a whacked-out idea comes to us first, which is good." What is even more impressive is that Maddock has hit the peak without banking on superstars. None of the three Khans, Ranbir Kapoor or Alia Bhatt has done a Maddock film yet. In fact, Maddock has contributed to the star content of actors like Deepika Padukone (*Love Aaj Kal* in 2009 and *Cocktail* in 2012) and Rajkummar Rao (the *Stree* films). But stars have wised up: Akshay Kumar had a small but significant part in *Stree 2*. For Vijan, it's more important to find stories that do justice to a star's presence.

Vijan's approach is to not tie up directors with contracts. "You feel free. You can express yourself better," says filmmaker Laxman Utekar, who has directed four Maddock films, including *Chhaava*. "Dino doesn't sit with a calculator; he is emotionally involved in the film."

Each Maddock film begins with a tribute to Dino's father, Prem, a Mumbai-based businessman who inspired Vijan profoundly, including passing on the filmi *keeda* by taking him to the movies every Sunday. Vijan studied for an MBA in Mumbai and worked as an investment banker before pivoting to films. "Without him, I wouldn't be the person I am, make the films I do and go through the hurdles I did," he says. Vijan credits his father with shaping his understanding of India by exposing him to the country's diverse realities and cultures during their family

"HE IS TRULY FOCUSED TO FIND STORIES FROM OUR OWN CULTURE, OWN LAND AND HISTORY. THAT VIEWPOINT IS THE MAGIC MASALA TO PUT INDIAN CINEMA ON THE GLOBAL MAP"

VICKY KAUSHAL
Actor, *Chhaava*





MIMI (2021)

The Covid pandemic meant that this drama about an aspiring actor-turned-surrogate mother had to opt for a release on Netflix. It turned around the careers of Sanon and Tripathi, who both won National Awards

"IF HE BELIEVES IN A PROJECT OR YOU, DINESH DOESN'T CARE ABOUT WHAT OTHERS SAY. IT IS EASY TO GET AFFECTED BY CHATTER, BUT HE REALLY BACKS HIS PEOPLE AND CONTENT"

KRITI SANON, Actress, *Mimi* and *Luka Chuppi*